

IAS PRELIMS/MAINS

Ecology & Environment

A stylized illustration of a green city skyline with various skyscrapers, wind turbines, and a sun, set against a light green background with a globe-like shape.

A COMPREHENSIVE COVERAGE

MODULE - 33

SOLID WASTE - 2

CHAPTER - I – SOLID WASTE

PLASTIC WASTE MANAGEMENT RULES, 2016

The MOEF had notified the Plastic Waste Management Rules, 2016, replacing the earlier rules of 2011.

KEY FEATURES

1 REGULATION OF PLASTICS

Increase minimum thickness of plastic carry bags from 40 to 50 microns and stipulate minimum thickness of 50 micron for plastic sheets.



WHAT IS THE BENEFIT OF INCREASING THICKNESS?

- Increasing the thickness of plastic carry bags from 40 to 50 micron and stipulation of 50 micron thickness for plastic sheets is likely to increase the cost by about 20%. Hence, the tendency to provide free carry bags will come down.
- Thin plastics have fewer incentives for rag pickers and hence less chance to get recycled. Collection of plastic bags by the rag-pickers will increase to some extent if the thickness of plastics is increased.
- Thin plastic bags having thickness below 40 microns are difficult to collect and manage.



KEY FEATURES

2

WIDER JURISDICTION - RURAL AREAS ARE COVERED

- Expanding the jurisdiction of applicability from the municipal area to rural areas, because plastic has reached rural areas also.
- The rules, which were previously applicable to municipal areas, have now been extended to all villages.
- Responsibility for implementation of the rules is given to Gram Panchayat.



KEY FEATURES

3

MORE RESPONSIBILITY TO PRODUCERS AND GENERATORS OF WASTE- EPR (EXTENDED PRODUCER RESPONSIBILITY)

Bringing in the responsibilities of producers and generators in plastic waste management and introducing collect back system of plastic waste by the producers/brand owners, as per extended producers' responsibility.

EXTENDED PRODUCER RESPONSIBILITY

- In the field of waste management, Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) is a policy approach under which producers are given a significant responsibility – financial and/or physical – for the treatment or disposal of post-consumer products.
- EPR is an environmental protection strategy to achieve the objective of a decreased total environmental impact of a product, by making the manufacturer of the product responsible for the entire life-cycle of the product, especially for the take-back, recycling and final disposal.



KEY FEATURES

4

PENALTIES

The rules also have the provision to fine retailers and street vendors who provide their products in plastic packaging which do not conform to the new rules.



5

SEGREGATION AT SOURCE

Individual and bulk waste generators like offices, commercial establishments, industries are to segregate the plastic waste at source and should handover the segregated waste and pay user fee as per the laws of the local bodies.



KEY FEATURES

6 MANAGEMENT AT SOURCE

Persons organizing public events like marriages, public gatherings are responsible for the management of waste generated during these events.



7 RECYCLING AND GAINFUL UTILIZATION

The rules promote use of plastic waste for road construction as per Indian Road Congress guidelines or conversion of plastic waste to fuel.



HAZARDOUS WASTE

- Any substance that causes damage to public health.
- Any dangerous waste that exhibits any one or more of the following characteristics- Toxicity, Reactivity, Corrosivity, Radioactivity, Ignitability etc.
- The MOEF defines hazardous waste as any waste which due to its physical, chemical or biological composition is likely to harm health or environment.
- Various industries in India such as petrochemicals, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, fertilizers etc, produce hazardous wastes in considerable quantities.
- Hospitals also generate hazardous wastes that contain disinfectants, pathogens, harmful chemicals etc. So hospital or medical waste is also considered to be hazardous. The use of incinerators is very importance to disposal of hospital waste.



BASEL CONVENTION

- **Objective** - This was designed to reduce the movements of hazardous waste between the nations, especially from development nations to less development nation.
- India is a party to the convention.
- Main goal is to prevent transfer of hazardous waste from developed to Less Developed Countries (LDCs).
- It does not address the movement of radioactive waste.
- Wastes such as Mercury containing wastes, E-Waste, Asbestos etc, are recognized by the convention as hazardous waste.
- 182 states and the European Union are parties to the Convention.



BASEL CONVENTION

*the world environmental
agreement on wastes*



ROTTERDAM CONVENTION

- Rotterdam Convention on the Prior Informed Consent Procedure for Certain Hazardous Chemicals and Pesticides in International Trade.
- Multilateral treaty to promote shared responsibilities in relation to importation of hazardous chemicals.
- India is a party to the convention.
- **Objective** - The convention promotes open exchange of information and calls on exporters and producers of hazardous chemicals to use proper labelling, safe handling, and inform purchasers of any known dangers.
- Signatory nations can decide whether to allow or ban the importation of chemicals listed in the treaty, and exporting countries are obliged to make sure that producers within their jurisdiction comply.

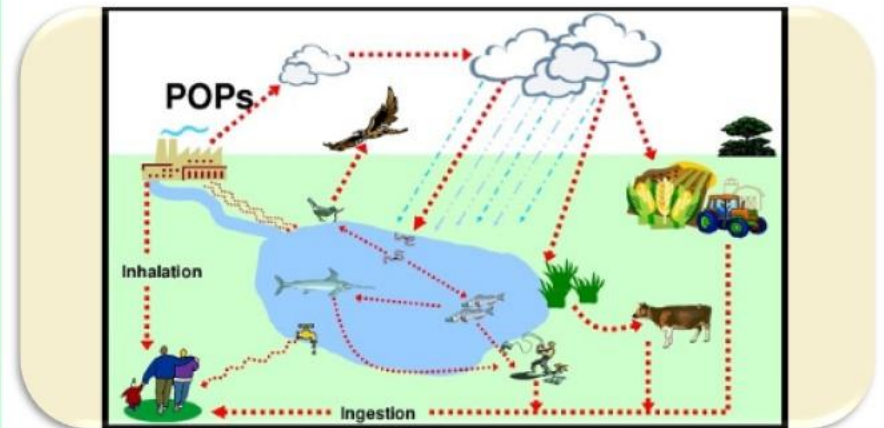


PERSISTENT ORGANIC POLLUTANTS (POPS)

Persistent Organic Pollutants (POPs) are organic compounds that resist environmental breakdown, some taking as long as a century to degrade.

HARMFUL EFFECTS OF POPS

- They are highly toxic to humans and wildlife.
- They can last for many years in the environment before degrading into less dangerous forms.
- They bio-accumulate in the food chain, they enter into the body of organisms from the environment and they get concentrated in the fatty tissues of organisms.
- They are transported over large distances through air and water and can be found worldwide.
- POPS therefore can be found globally, even in areas such as the Arctic and Antarctica, far from their source.
- Although many countries have banned these chemicals, they are produced or used illegally, or, because of lengthy lives, they continue to exist in the environment.



STOCKHOLM CONVENTION ON PERSISTENT ORGANIC POLLUTANTS

- The Stockholm Convention on Persistent Organic Pollutants is a global treaty to protect human health and the environment from POPs.
- Given their long range transport, no one government acting alone can protect its citizens or its environment from POPs.
- In response to this global problem, the Stockholm Convention, which was signed in 2001 and entered into force in 2004,
- The Convention requires its parties to take measures to eliminate or reduce the release of POPs into the environment.



MAIN PROVISIONS

The Convention requires each party to -

- Prohibit and/or eliminate the production and use, as well as the import and export, of the POPs that are listed in Annex A.
- Annex A allows for the registration of specific exemptions for the production or use of listed POPs. The import and export of chemicals listed in Annex A can take place under specific restrictive conditions.
- Restrict the production and use, as well as the import and export, of the POPs that are listed in Annex B.
- Annex B allows for the registration of acceptable purposes for the production and use of the listed POPs. The import and export of chemicals listed in Annex B can take place under specific restrictive conditions.
- Reduce or eliminate releases from the POPs that are listed in Annex C.



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